

Vertigo

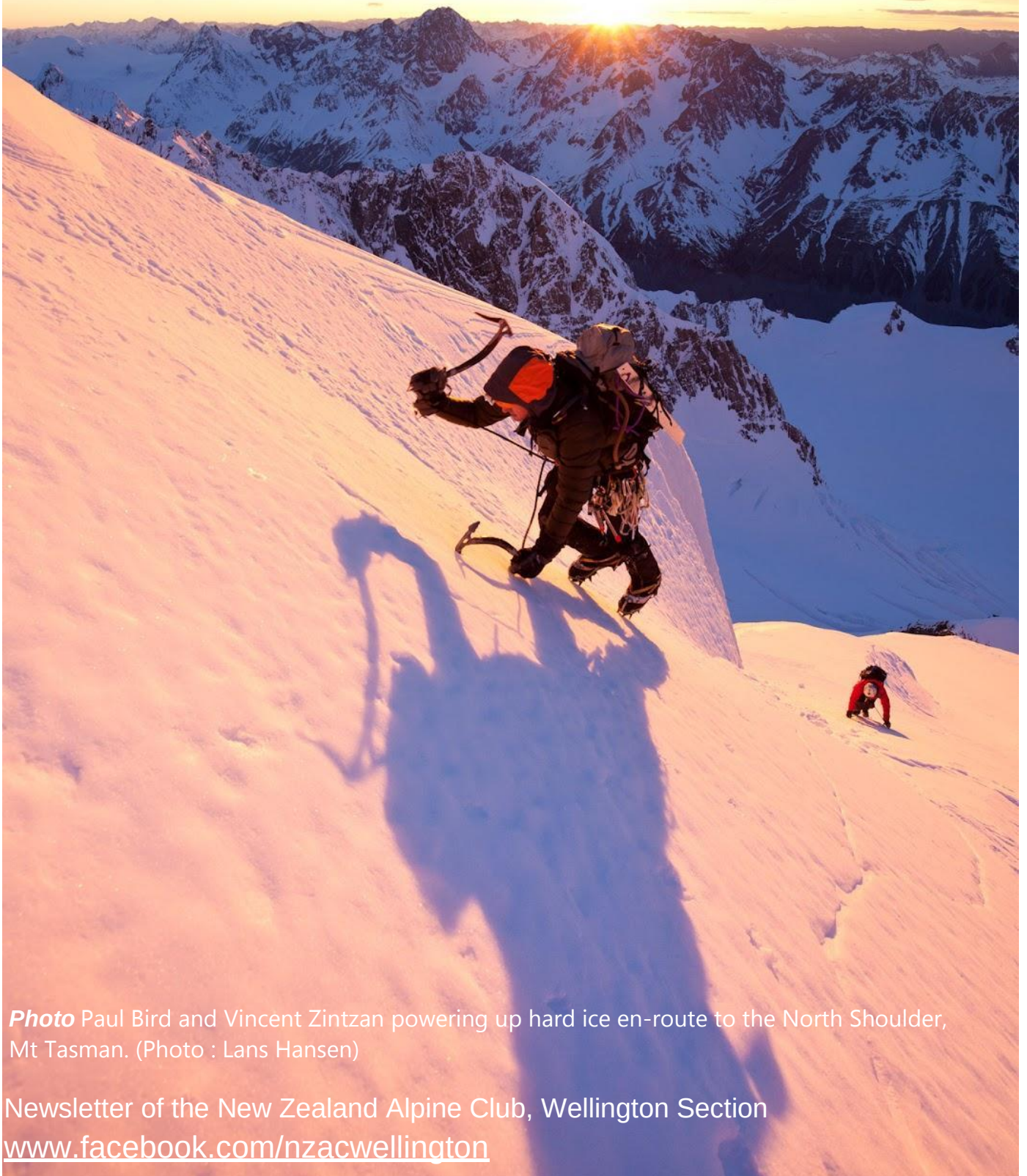


Photo Paul Bird and Vincent Zintzan powering up hard ice en-route to the North Shoulder, Mt Tasman. (Photo : Lans Hansen)

Newsletter of the New Zealand Alpine Club, Wellington Section

www.facebook.com/nzacwellington

Section News

November section night – Wellington Section AGM

The Wellington Section AGM will be held Monday 10 November 2014. Please join us for a cuppa or a beer at the TTC Clubrooms, Mt. Victoria at 8pm.

We are still seeking keen members for Committee and non-committee roles to support the Section's activities. Steady experienced hands through to new energetic members are all welcome! In particular, a Treasurer is needed as Adam is moving overseas shortly.

PS: Our website should be back up shortly after our hosting service folded and we needed to find a new one and recover the site. In the meantime, check out our Facebook page: <https://www.facebook.com/nzacwellington?ref=hl> Thanks for your patience.

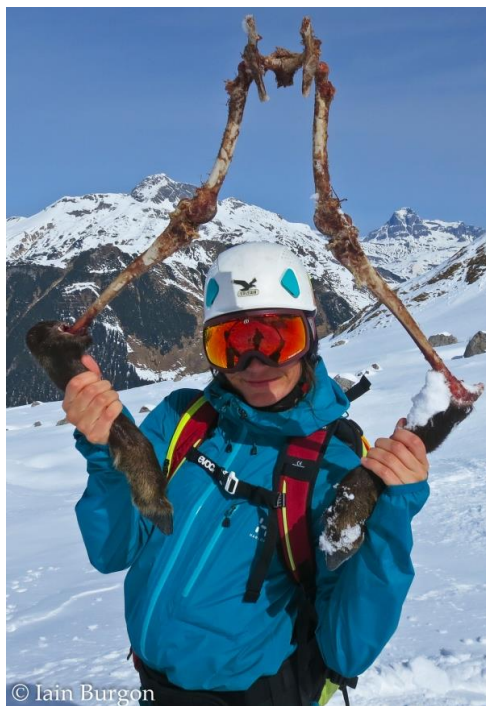
Section Nights are usually at the Tararua Tramping Club clubrooms, 4 Moncrieff Street, Mount Victoria, Wellington on the second Monday of every month. New and prospective members are welcome. Meetings start 8.00 pm with tea & coffee afterwards

Section Photo Competition Winning Photos

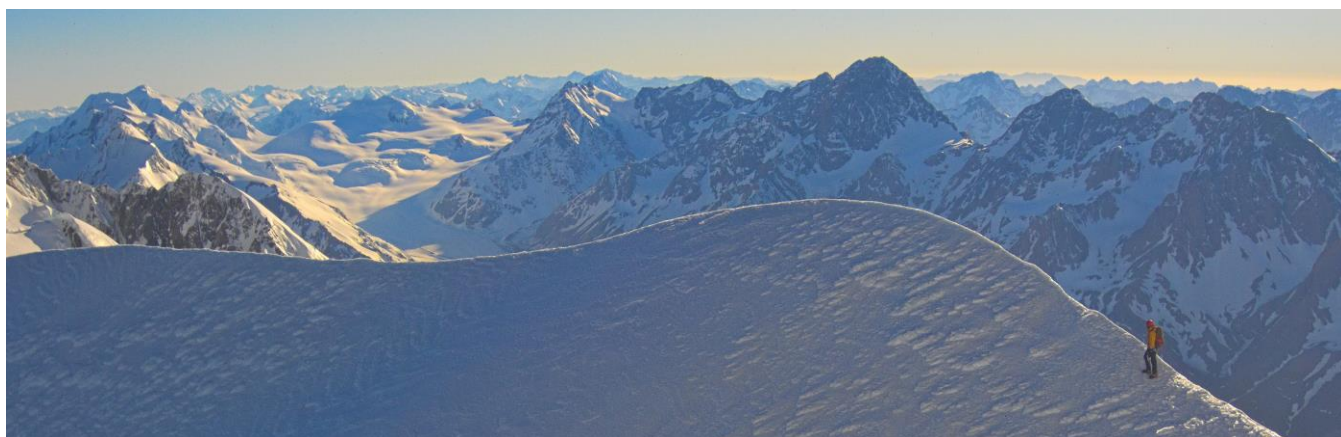
For those who missed the last section night, here are the winning photos from the section photo competition.



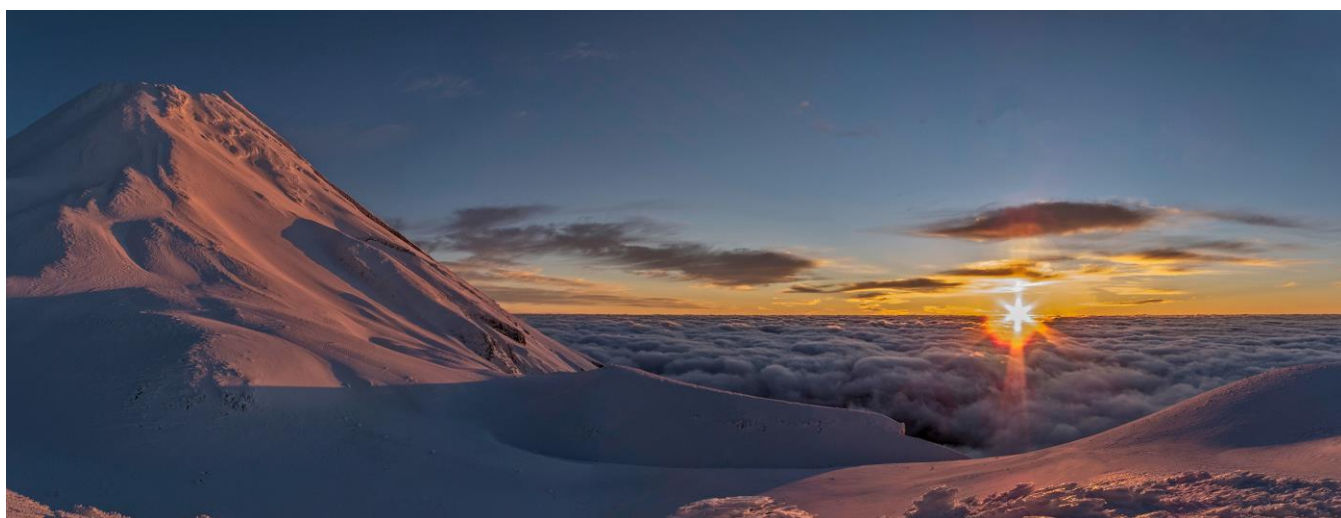
Winner Photojournalism category - Porter - by Derek Cheng



Winner Humour Category - New Knees by Iain Burgon



Winner Alpine Activity Category - Walking Along the Main Divide by Simon Bell



Winner Alpine General Category - Dawn on Fantham's Peak by Peter Laurenson



Winner Alpine Nature Category - Bull Protecting Alpine Lake in Cordillera Blanca by Andre Lazelle



Winner Rock Climbing Category - Aquatic Climbing by Vincent Zintzan

Trip Report

Mt Tasman

Photos and Text by Lans Hansen



After 3 weeks of waiting with bags packed, watching weather reports and praying a nice big high would make its home over the South Island, we were off. We were amped; that morning's long range forecast showed four perfect days in the Mt Cook National Park, after plenty of time for the last storm's dump to consolidate. Great, we thought, as we boarded the next available Interislander.

This was to be my first major mountain trip, joining the veteran team of John Yu (China), Vincent Zintzen (VeeZee), and Paul Bird (The Bird). After some successful climbs over the past seasons, Tasman was the next big summit on their list. For myself, a fine-weather sport climber and somewhat hesitant mountaineer it was an opportunity too good to pass up!

Not four hours later, as we pull into Picton, we get word that there's a storm coming, and now the forecast showed gale force winds and rain on 3 of our days! Hopes dashed! Suddenly my idea of summiting on a nice blue sky day and having tea on the summit was replaced with a vision of us pinned to the mountain by a tempest storm, with me having to warm The Bird's frozen hands with my armpits. (I heard rumours that this happened during one of their training trip to Ruapehu, but no-one talks about it of course except when it is time to play with The Bird). It seems I wasn't the only one with my doubts, and we pondered with the options of turning around and waiting for a better window, or keeping on heading south and hope for the best? After wrestling with the decision for an hour we decided to just camp in St Arnaud for the night and check again in the morning. The following day the report had marginally

improved, and with encouragement from VeeZee who was already on the West Coast, sunbathing coolly, we set off somewhat hesitantly.

When we arrived in Fox Glacier town later that day - after several hours checking phones for updated forecasts - the weather was no more encouraging: patchy rain and overcast. The vision of the tempest still fresh in my mind, I was relieved to have a night of respite at Porters Lodge, with another day for us to decide this was all madness and go back to sport climbing at Kawakawa Bay, or somewhere else calm and sunny, with a beach and bolts.

The following day was clearer and we collectively decided to take a helicopter into Pioneer hut for the chance we would get a good day. The chopper lifted off and we were committed; the weeks of weather report watching and waiting were over and it felt great. Plus, helicopters are awesome (that was my first ride)!



Saturday, we landed on the glacier at 11am on a still morning and our objective was clearly visible... but the hut was not. Nowhere in sight, it was almost completely buried.



To our delight somebody had already dug out the entrance: the hut book read. "Dug out the entrance. Took 2 hours!"



Our planned route up Mt Tasman Via the North shoulder

Over lunch we decided on our plan: head out across the glacier during daylight to find a route around the crevasses, then have a day's acclimatisation before the forecast better weather/summit day on Monday.



Route finding up the glacier was relatively simple, with the exception of one snow bridge we had to cross 'under fire' from ice debris falling from Mt Haast above.



After 2 hours plugging steps in ankle-deep snow we were close to Marcel Col and decided to head back down to hear the 5.15pm radio weather report for the following days.



Tasman shrouded in cloud on Saturday evening with our freshly made track running out across the glacier.

With forecast "...winds rising to gale" on Monday's planned summit day, we concluded that our *best* option was to climb tomorrow, or rather in 6 hours, when the weather was only "strong winds and patches of rain". After a final look at our objective, still veiled in cloud (above) we retired to the hut for the night to get what sleep we could.

We roped up and set off from the hut at 1:30am, following our tracks back across the glacier as patchy clouds drifted around us in the dark. The wind that had been forecast the entire trip was nowhere to be seen and we made good time climbing Lendenfeld and descending the other side to Engineers Col. From here, we knew the long ridge leading up to Tasman's North Shoulder should begin, but our quick pace meant we arrived in the pitch black, and all we could make out was the presence of an ice cliff that threatened the steep ridge rising into the blackness before us. After pondering several unappealing route options we decided to dig a ledge in the ice encrusted slope and wait for first light in the hope a better route would become apparent. After 45 minutes and several near incidents with us drifting off to sleep - only waking mid-slump towards the void that ran off below us - we could see the full serac, and right underneath a promising route.



Beginning the climb up to the ice cliffs, with Lendenfeld in the background.

Feeling positive about the route and keen to get moving as fast as possible to avoid spending too much time under this massive serac, we set out, soloing on a mixture of hard ice covered in places with deep powder. By now the face was illuminated with surreal pink alpenglow that contrasted the cold blue world we had emerged from, and our exposed position and incredible surroundings became apparent.

Once around the ice cliffs, it was a calf-burning but relatively straightforward 200m climb, front pointing on good ice to regain the ridge and, shortly afterwards, the North Shoulder.



From here we could see across to the summits of Cook and Tasman, the latter still so far away. We traversed along the shoulder and came to the second 'fun' part, rumoured to be called the Notch. We quickly understood why the nickname...The ridge we followed narrowed to an ice encrusted knife edge, with 1km drops either side to the glaciers below.



China delicately crossing the icy ridge

China set out to investigate the ridge, and to my relief, we made the call that we should pitch this section. Even with the rope, it was nervous climbing: crossing the icy ridge required a balancing act, and once over it was straight into steep, loose powder over rock-hard ice. After burrowing through a foot of powder China was able to place a couple of ice screws along the pitch, but with the ice so hard it took both hands to crank the handles.



The Bird on pitch 2 as the wind began to pick up.

After two full pitches, the slope eased for the final hundred meters to the summit. Leaving the ropes, we made our way up to meet China and VeeZee on the Tasman's summit just on 9:45AM for a quick celebration in strong winds.



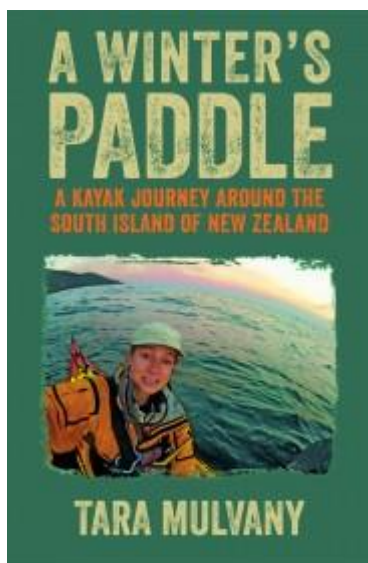
The Bird on the last snow slope before the summit

Our ascent route had been sheltered from the brunt of the wind but, exposed on the summit, it was hard to stand, and in the minutes we spent there we saw lenticular clouds beginning to form out over Cook to the South. Eager to get back past the exposed slopes we knew we still had to solo back down, we set off. Back on the glacier, the cloud poured in and we walked the last hour in complete white-out, following our tracks in silence while struggling to make sense of all the whiteness in our exhausted states. We made it back to Pioneer hut after 13 hours on the go where we collapsed with cups of soup and The Bird uncovered the nastiest blister I have ever seen.

The following day we choppered out and headed back up for the Picton ferry via the Hari Hari Hot pools, feeling deeply satisfied with our trip and ready to go climb somewhere warm for a bit!

Notices

20% discount – A Long Cold Paddle – Craig Potton Publishing



A Long Cold Paddle by Tara Mulvany is on special with 20% discount until the end of the year. Please log in online for member rates:

<https://alpineclub.org.nz/news/2014/craig-potton-publishing/a-long-cold-paddle/discount>

Member enquiry from back in the day:

E H Sealy joined the Alpine club in 1937 as an Associate Member, becoming a full member in 1938. He was from Cambridge, England. Does anyone know his correct nickname - Ched, Chid possibly? Margaret@alpineclub.org.nz

How about supporting Rebecca in raising funds for Oxfam?



Rebecca Cox has decided to take on a life changing challenge - walk the length of Aotearoa to raise funds for Oxfam's Rural Training centres in Vanuatu. - See more at:

<http://www.oxfam.org.nz/fundraise/trekking-today-training-tomorrow>

Foundation Ropes Rescue Course

SARINZ are running a Foundation Ropes Rescue Course where the overall objective of the course is to safely and efficiently operate rope rescue in low angle terrain and protect personal safety at an edge. The dates and final cost of the course are still to be confirmed but, if you're interested, please ring (03) 348 6654 or email info@sarinz.com. Further details on the course are at <http://www.sarinz.com/index.cfm/3,177,338/foundation-rope-rescue.pdf>

Aspiring Hut Fee Increases

From Friday 24 October 2014 hut fees for Aspiring, Colin Todd and French Ridge Huts will increase by \$5 per night. The NZAC member and Youth rates (11-17yrs of age) will each be \$15 per night. The non-member rate increases to \$25 per night. A peak-rate for Aspiring only of \$30 for non members will apply during the months October to April.

Esquilant Bivvy also falls under this agreement, but there will be no change to the \$5 member/youth and \$10 non-member rate.

Alpine Club spare books for sale

The Alpine Club has a number of spare donated books for sale at \$5 each plus p&p. Postage within NZ is \$6 for the first book and \$2 each subsequent book. If posting overseas please enquire as postage rates differ. All books are in a fair condition and sold as is. Please contact Margaret@alpineclub.org.nz if you have any enquiries and to check that the item you would like is still available. Details of the books are at : <https://alpineclub.org.nz/news/2014/spare-books-for-sale>

Book Project

Ray Salisbury from the Nelson Tramping Club has begun the long process of writing another book. The working title of the book is **TALES FROM THE TABLELAND ... the history behind Mt Arthur**. He is hoping to gather together more stories about the Tableland / Mt Arthur area - part of the research. Anyone with some old tales to tell please contact Ray Tel: (021) 135 8739 Email: hotpixels@maxnet.co.nz

Ray is running a Kickstarter campaign which ends on Sunday 9 November. Many people have been exceedingly generous; if that's you: 'you are awesome!'. There's time to raise the remaining money needed to get this book written so if you've been sitting on that proverbial fence, now's the time to invest! Even if it's \$10.00. Otherwise, the book won't get written, and we'll all be the poorer for it.

And, if you haven't viewed the video.... Check out the freebies on Kickstarter here: [TALES FROM THE TABLELAND ... the history behind Mt Arthur](#).

Choose from 2015 calendars, diaries, greeting cards - all great for Christmas presents - all limited editions featuring Ray's landscape photography.

Wellington Section 2013/14 contacts list

We are always thankful for volunteers and members stepping forward to help the section run smoothly. If you'd like to learn more about how you could get involved, please email us at wellington@alpineclub.org.nz

Position	Name	Email alias*	Contact
Chairperson	Dan Pringle	chairperson	027 768-2185
Vice Chair	Vincent Zintzen	vicechair	
Secretary	Julian Davidson	secretary or CM2	
Treasurer	Adam Newberry	treasurer	
National Rep	Dan Pringle		
Patron	John Nankervis		
Trips	Vacant	Trips	
Other Committee Members	Simon Williamson		
	John Yu		
	Sharran Came		
Other Roles:			
Gear	vacant	gear	
Personal Locator Beacons	vacant	PLB	
Instruction Coordinator	vacant		
Instruction - AIC	vacant		
Instruction - Rock	vacant		
Library	Joke Meerkens	library	
Newsletter Editor	Carolyn Ellis		Kaz1963@gmail.com
Rock Drill Overseer	Kristen Foley	drill or KF	
Website	John Yu	webmaster	
* Email address is: alias@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz eg. secretary@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz			
Any membership, Distaghil Sar Fund, or general queries should be directed to the secretary			
Any media queries should be directed to:			
03 3777 595	National Executive Officer	Sam Newton	sam@alpineclub.org.nz



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